



Embracing Me

A Guide to Understanding, Growing, and Thriving

NAME:

YEAR:

Strong roots, space to flourish.



Contents

1

Understanding My Brain

2

Sensory Processing and Regulation

3

Emotions and Self-Regulation

4

Socialising and Communication

5

School and Learning

6

Self-Advocacy and Self-Esteem

7

My Personal Profile



1

Understanding my Brain

Start here to learn how your amazing brain works, and what makes you, you.

- What is Autism?
- Autism Myths vs. Facts
- Different Ways Autism Can Look and Feel
- My Strengths as an Autistic Person



What is Autism?

Autism is a way of thinking, feeling, and experiencing the world that is different from how many other people do. Your brain is wired in a unique way, which means you might notice things that others miss, have strong interests in certain topics, or find some situations overwhelming. Autism can affect how you understand emotions, communicate with others, and deal with sensory experiences like sounds, lights, and textures.

Autism isn't something that needs to be "fixed" - it's just a different way of being. The world is made up of all kinds of brains, and yours is just as important as anyone else's.





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What's one thing about your brain that makes you, you?

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Autism Myths vs. Facts

There are a lot of misunderstandings about autism. Some people believe things that aren't true, which can make it harder for autistic people to feel accepted. Let's look at some common myths and the real facts about autism:

MYTH

Autistic people don't have emotions.

FACT

Autistic people feel emotions just as much (or even more than) others! Sometimes, it might be hard to show or explain feelings in a way that people understand or expect, but that doesn't mean you don't have them, or that you are not allowed to have big emotions.

MYTH

All autistic people are the same.

FACT

Every autistic person is different! Some love talking, while others prefer quiet. Some enjoy routines, and others don't mind change. Autism is a spectrum, which means it looks different for everyone.

MYTH

Autism is something to "fix".

FACT

There is nothing wrong with being autistic - it's part of who you are. The goal is never to change you, but to find ways to make life work for you.

MYTH

Autistic people can't have friends or relationships.

FACT

Autistic people can have great friendships and relationships! You might socialise in a different way or need more time to connect with people, but that doesn't mean you can't build strong relationships.





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Had you heard any of these myths before? How did the facts make you feel?

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Different Ways Autism Can Look and Feel

Autism isn't one single experience - it looks and feels different for everyone. Some autistic people:

- Love routines and predictability - knowing what will happen next feels safe and comfortable.
- Are very creative or love problem-solving - thinking differently can lead to amazing ideas.
- Have deep interests in specific topics - you might focus on something you love and learn everything about it.
- Need more time to process conversations or instructions - your brain might take a little longer to sort through information, which is completely okay.
- Experience sensory things more strongly - lights might feel too bright, sounds too loud, or certain textures uncomfortable.
- Communicate in different ways - you might prefer writing or using pictures instead of talking, or you may need extra time to put thoughts into words.

You might experience all of these things, just a few, or even different things not listed here. However you experience autism, it is valid and important.

What things, either listed here or not, do you experience?





Write or draw here

Which of these feel true for you? Write or draw your own examples.



My Strengths

Being autistic comes with amazing strengths! Here are some of the things that make autistic people unique:

- Attention to detail - you might notice small things that other people miss, which can be a great skill in art, science, gaming, or problem-solving.
- Deep focus - when you're interested in something, you can focus on it for hours and become an expert!
- Creativity and originality - many autistic people have unique ways of thinking, leading to brilliant ideas in writing, art, music, and technology.
- Strong memory - you might remember facts, numbers, patterns, or lyrics better than others.
- Honesty and loyalty - many autistic people are very honest, straightforward, and loyal friends.
- Thinking differently - you might come up with solutions or ideas that no one else would think of.
- Strong sense of justice - autistic people often care deeply about fairness and doing the right thing.

By understanding how your brain works, you can use your strengths to help you in school, friendships, and life.

What strengths do you think you have?





Write or draw here

Which strengths sound like you? What would you add to the list?



2

Sensory Processing and Regulation

Discover how your senses work, and build your own toolkit for feeling comfortable.

- How my Senses Work
- What Helps Me Feel Safe and Comfortable
- Managing Overwhelm
- Creating my Sensory Toolkit



How my senses work

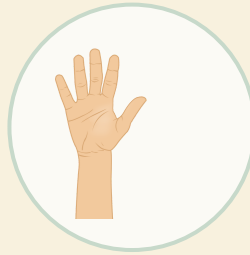
Some people experience the world differently because their senses can be more sensitive (hypersensitive) or less sensitive (hyposensitive) than other people's. This can affect how things feel, sound, taste, smell, and look. You might be hypersensitive in some areas and hyposensitive in others! Your mood, tiredness, and energy levels can also affect how sensitive you are to your senses.



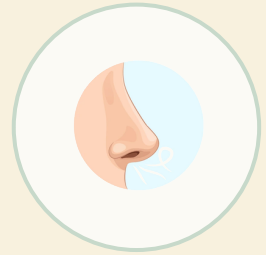
Sight



Sound



Touch



Smell



Taste



Balance



Body Awareness

Highlight what sensory experiences you have on the following pages.

How my senses work

Sight



HYPERSENSITIVE (over-sensitive)

- Bright lights (like classroom lights, car headlights, or sunlight) might hurt your eyes.
- Flickering or flashing lights (like in supermarkets or on screens) might feel distracting or stressful.
- Busy patterns or too many colours can feel overwhelming or confusing.
- You might notice tiny details that others miss (like a small stain on someone's clothes or flickering on a screen).

HYPOSENSITIVE (under-sensitive)

- You might not notice small visual details (like someone's facial expressions or a sign on the wall).
- You may enjoy bright lights and colours because they give you more sensory input.
- You might have trouble judging distances (like reaching for something and missing it or misjudging steps on stairs).
- Things might sometimes look blurry or out of focus unless you move closer.

Do any of these sound like you? Circle or highlight the ones that do.



How my senses work

Sound



HYPERSENSITIVE (over-sensitive)

- Loud noises (like alarms, sirens, school bells, or shouting) might feel painful.
- Background noise (like ticking clocks, buzzing lights, or people talking) can be hard to ignore.
- Sudden sounds (like a dog barking or someone clapping) might make you jump or feel anxious.
- You might prefer quiet spaces and feel exhausted after being in noisy environments.

HYPOSENSITIVE (under-sensitive)

- You might not notice when someone calls your name or speaks to you.
- You might enjoy loud music, banging objects, or making noise because it helps you focus.
- You might talk loudly without realising it, or enjoy repeating certain sounds.
- You might find silence uncomfortable and prefer to have background noise (like a fan, TV, or music).

Do any of these sound like you? Circle or highlight the ones that do.



How my senses work

Touch



HYPERSENSITIVE (over-sensitive)

- Certain fabrics, clothing tags, or seams might feel unbearable.
- Light touches (like someone brushing past you) might feel painful or overwhelming.
- You might not like hugs or physical contact unless it's on your terms.
- Washing, brushing hair, or cutting nails might feel too intense or uncomfortable.

HYPOSENSITIVE (under-sensitive)

- You might not notice small injuries (like cuts or bruises) until later.
- You might seek out deep pressure (like tight hugs, weighted blankets, or squeezing things).
- You might enjoy touching different textures, like soft fabrics or rough surfaces.
- You might have a high pain tolerance and not react much to things like hot or cold temperatures.

Do any of these sound like you? Circle or highlight the ones that do.



How my senses work

Smell



HYPERSENSITIVE (over-sensitive)

- Strong smells (like perfume, cleaning products, or food) might feel overwhelming or even make you feel sick.
- You might be able to smell things that others don't notice (like a distant flower or someone's shampoo).
- Smells can distract or upset you, making it hard to focus.
- You might avoid certain places (like canteens, supermarkets, or public toilets) because of strong odours.

HYPOSENSITIVE (under-sensitive)

- You might not notice bad smells (like spoiled food or smoke).
- You may enjoy strong scents and seek them out (like smelling objects or certain food repeatedly).
- You might not react to things that others find too smelly (like strong perfumes or air fresheners).

Do any of these sound like you? Circle or highlight the ones that do.



How my senses work

Taste



HYPERSENSITIVE (over-sensitive)

- Some foods might taste too strong, spicy, or bitter, even if other people think they're mild.
- Certain textures (like mushy, crunchy, or slimy foods) might be unbearable.
- You might prefer plain foods with simple flavours.
- You might find eating in noisy or busy places (like the school canteen or hall) stressful.

HYPOSENSITIVE (under-sensitive)

- You might not notice strong flavours and prefer very spicy or salty foods.
- You may enjoy chewy or crunchy textures because they give you more sensory input.
- You might not notice when food is too hot or too cold.

Do any of these sound like you? Circle or highlight the ones that do.



Balance and Movement (Vestibular)



HYPERSENSITIVE (over-sensitive)

- Fast movements (like running, spinning, or going on rides) might feel scary or overwhelming.
- You might feel dizzy or unsteady easily.
- Walking on uneven surfaces (like grass or sand) might make you feel uncomfortable or unsafe.
- You might feel anxious about climbing, jumping, or moving too quickly.

HYPOSENSITIVE (under-sensitive)

- You might love spinning, swimming, or running in circles because it feels good.
- You may not feel dizzy even after spinning a lot.
- You might rock back and forth or move around a lot to help your body feel balanced.
- You may need to fidget, tap your foot, or bounce to stay focused.

Do any of these sound like you? Circle or highlight the ones that do.

Body Awareness (Proprioception)



HYPERSENSITIVE (over-sensitive)

- You might feel uncomfortable with certain types of movement, like stretching or bending.
- You may struggle with sports or activities that require balance.
- You might feel "too aware" of your body, which can make you feel stiff or uncomfortable.

HYPOSENSITIVE (under-sensitive)

- You might bump into things or misjudge distances.
- You might prefer to sit on your feet or not notice when holding something tightly.
- You may enjoy strong physical activities like jumping, climbing, or lifting heavy objects.
- You might need to press hard when writing or prefer tight clothes for a sense of pressure.

Do any of these sound like you? Circle or highlight the ones that do.

My Body's Internal Signals

HYPERSENSITIVE (over-sensitive)

- Hunger and Thirst: hunger or thirst might feel overwhelming, making it hard to focus.
- Temperature: you might feel extremely hot or cold in normal temperatures.
- Pain and Injury: small pains (like a scratch, bruise, or tight clothing) might feel very intense.
- Toileting: the feeling of needing the toilet might feel very urgent or uncomfortable.

HYPOSENSITIVE (under-sensitive)

- Hunger and Thirst: you might forget to eat or drink because you don't feel hunger or thirst strongly.
- Temperature: you might not notice when you're too hot or too cold until someone else points it out.
- Pain and Injury: you might not notice or react to injuries (like cuts, bruises, or burns).
- Toileting: you might not notice or forget to go, until it's urgent, because you don't feel the signals strongly.

Do any of these sound like you? Circle or highlight the ones that do.

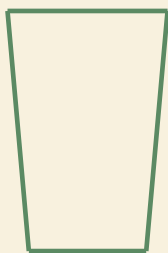


My Sensory Profile

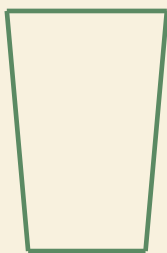
Colour in the cups to show if you are Hypersensitive (over-sensitive) or Hyposensitive (under-sensitive) to each sense.

Hypersensitive = water spilling out of the cup. Hyposensitive = only a little water in the cup.

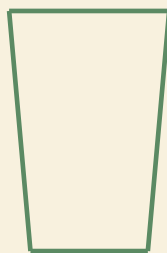
Having your cups filled, but not overflowing, can help you feel calm and not overwhelmed.



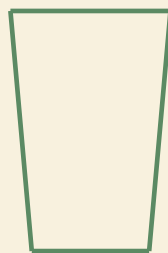
Sight



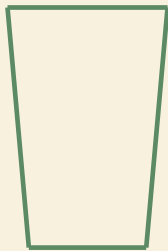
Sound



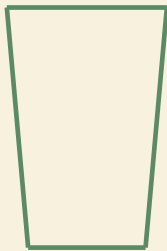
Touch



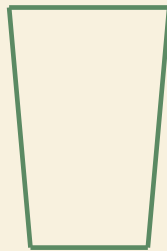
Smell



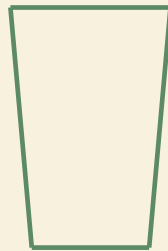
Taste



Balance and
Movement



Body
Awareness



Interoception



What Helps Me Feel Safe and Comfortable

You may need certain things to feel comfortable and safe. Here are some ways people manage their sensory needs:

- Wearing comfy clothes - some fabrics might feel too stretchy, tight, or loose, so choosing clothes that work for you can help.
- Using headphones or ear defenders - you can use headphones for more sound input, or ear defenders to block out unwanted sounds.
- Dimming lights or wearing sunglasses - bright or flickering lights can be uncomfortable, so adjusting lighting can help.
- Using fidget tools - the right fidget tools (tailored to your needs) can help with focus and make your body feel calmer.
- Chewing gum or eating crunchy foods - some people like strong tastes or chewing to help them focus and feel calm.
- Moving around - if your body needs movement, things like walking or stretching can help.

What things do you think may help you feel safe and comfortable?





Write or draw here

What helps you feel safe and comfortable? Write or draw your ideas.

A large rectangular area for writing or drawing, featuring horizontal light blue lines and a vertical brown line on the left side.



Managing Overwhelm

Sometimes, too much sensory input can lead to sensory overload. This means your brain is receiving too much information at once, and it can feel overwhelming, exhausting, or even painful.

When this happens, you might feel:

- Frustrated or angry
- Like you need to escape or hide
- Stuck and unable to think clearly
- Like your body is too full of energy, or completely frozen

When you start feeling overwhelmed, try these strategies:

- Step away from the situation - find a quiet, safe space where you can calm down.
- Use your sensory toolkit - put on headphones, use a fidget tool, or wrap up in a soft blanket.
- Try deep pressure or movement - hug a pillow, squeeze a stress ball, or do a few big stretches.
- Use calming activities - listening to music or drawing can help you reset.
- Tell someone how you feel - if you can, let a trusted person know that you need a break or some support.

Knowing your sensory needs helps you take care of yourself. It's okay to ask for adjustments and to do what helps you feel comfortable in different environments.

What makes you feel overwhelmed? Who and what can help you when you feel overwhelmed?





Write or draw here

What makes you feel overwhelmed, and who or what helps?



My Sensory Toolkit

A sensory toolkit is a collection of things that help you feel comfortable and regulate your senses. It's different for everyone, but here are some ideas:

- For sound sensitivity: noise-cancelling headphones, calming music, or a quiet space.
- For feeling overwhelmed: a weighted blanket or plushy, fidget tools, or deep breathing exercises.
- For movement: a stress ball, stretchy bands, or a small trampoline.
- For focus and comfort: sensory snack boxes, colouring books, or a soft fabric to touch.

Having a sensory toolkit means you have the things you need to feel better when the world feels too loud, too bright, or too overwhelming.

Create your own sensory toolkit - think about what makes you feel calm and relaxed.





My Sensory Toolkit

Write or draw the things that help you feel calm and comfortable.



3

Emotions and Self-Regulation

Learn to understand and manage your emotions, in your own way.

- Understanding my Emotions
- How to Explain my Feelings to Others
- Strategies for Managing Anxiety and Overload
- My Emotional Regulation Toolkit



Understanding my Emotions

Emotions are feelings like happiness, sadness, excitement, anger, or worry. Everyone experiences emotions, but some people feel them in a very strong, overwhelming way, or struggle to recognise and describe them.

Why does this happen?

Two things can affect how some people experience emotions: interoception and alexithymia.

Interoception is the sense that helps you notice what's happening inside your body. It tells you if you're hungry, thirsty, too hot, in pain, or feeling emotions. If your interoception signals are too weak, you might not notice you're upset until you suddenly explode. If they are too strong, you might feel emotions so intensely that they take over.

Alexithymia is when it's hard to put feelings into words. You might know something is wrong but struggle to explain what or why. Instead of saying "I'm feeling worried", you might just feel restless or sick without knowing why.

What does this look like in real life?

- Feeling fine one moment and suddenly overwhelmed because emotions build up without you noticing.
- Getting angry or frustrated without knowing why - maybe because you're actually hungry or tired.
- Having a hard time explaining feelings to others, or needing more time to figure them out.
- Feeling numb or disconnected from emotions, like they are distant or confusing.

What can help?

- Using an emotions chart with faces and words to identify how you feel.
- Checking in with your body - are you hungry? Tired? Too hot or cold?
- Writing or drawing how you feel, even if you don't have the right words yet.





Write or draw here

How do you usually notice you're feeling an emotion?



How to Explain my Feelings to Others

It's okay to need help with your emotions, but others can't help unless they know what's wrong. Sometimes, explaining feelings can be really hard, especially if you find it hard to put feelings into words.

Ideas for ways you could communicate feelings:

- Using simple phrases - "I feel bad but don't know why", "Something is wrong".
- Using visuals - pointing to an emotion chart or using a colour system to show people how you feel.
- Using scripts - pre-written sentences like "I need space", or "I feel overwhelmed".
- Using a communication card - a small card that says "I need a break" or "I need help".





Write or draw here

Which of these ways of explaining feelings could you try?



Strategies for Managing Anxiety and Overload

Anxiety is a feeling of worry or nervousness. Some people often feel anxious because the world is unpredictable, too overwhelming, or because they have social worries.

What does anxiety feel like?

- A fast heartbeat or feeling shaky
- A tight chest or trouble breathing
- Feeling sick or dizzy
- Thoughts racing too fast
- Wanting to run away or hide

What can help?

- Predictability - knowing what will happen next can ease anxiety. Using a visual timetable or checklist can help.
- Self-soothing - having a "calm kit" or "sensory toolkit" with sensory tools, music, ear defenders, or comforting items.
- Grounding techniques - using the "5-4-3-2-1" method: name 5 things you see, 4 things you touch, 3 things you hear, 2 things you smell, 1 thing you taste.
- Safe spaces - finding a quiet place to go when overwhelmed (a corner, a room, or cuddled in a blanket).





Write or draw here

What does anxiety feel like for you, and what helps?

A large writing area consisting of 20 horizontal light blue lines. A vertical brown line runs down the left side of the area, starting from the first horizontal line and ending at the last one, creating a margin for writing.



My Emotional Regulation Toolkit

An emotional regulation toolkit is a collection of strategies and items that help you manage your feelings when things feel too overwhelming, frustrating, or stressful. Everyone's toolkit is unique, but here are some ideas:

- When you feel anxious or overwhelmed: try a deep breathing exercise, listen to calming music, or use a weighted blanket.
- When you feel frustrated or angry: squeeze a stress ball, rip up paper, or do some physical movement like star jumps or stretching.
- When you need to feel calm and safe: wrap yourself in a soft blanket, hold a comfort item, or use grounding techniques like naming 5 things you see, 4 things you touch, 3 things you hear, 2 things you smell, 1 thing you taste.
- When you need a break from people or noise: use noise-cancelling headphones, find a quiet space, or use a "do not disturb" signal.
- When you struggle to express your feelings: use an emotions chart, write in a journal, or draw how you feel.

Have a go at building yours with things that work best for you!





My Emotion Regulation Toolkit

Write or draw the strategies and items that help you feel calm.



4

Socialising and Communication

Explore your communication style, boundaries, and friendships.

- Understanding my Communication Style
- How to Set Boundaries and Say No
- How to Explain my Needs to Others
- Friendships: What Works for Me?



Understanding my Communication Style

Socialising can be fun, interesting, confusing, exhausting, or even stressful – sometimes all at once! Some people experience socialising and communication differently to other people. This doesn't mean something is wrong; it just means your brain processes social interactions in its own way.

Communication isn't just about talking – it's about how you process, understand, and respond to others. Some people may have a unique communication style that includes:

- Literal thinking – if someone tells you something, you may believe it to be true without understanding any hidden messages or social cues. In the same way, if they do not tell you something, you may not know it to be true or assume it yourself. Literal thinkers can struggle to understand instructions unless they are given in a very clear, literal way.
- Processing time – needing more time to think before responding.
- Social energy – feeling drained after social interactions and needing recovery time.

What does this look like in real life?

- Not noticing when people say things they don't really mean (e.g. "Let's hang out soon!" but they don't plan to).
- Struggling with sarcasm, indirect hints, or vague language (e.g. "We'll see" instead of a clear yes or no).
- Needing extra time to form a response, especially in fast conversations.
- Finding small talk uninteresting but enjoying deep, meaningful conversations.

What can help?

- Asking for clarity – "Do you mean that literally?"
- Using scripts – pre-planned responses for common situations (e.g. "I need a moment to think before I answer").
- Choosing comfortable social settings – talking one-to-one instead of in big groups.
- Giving yourself processing time – saying "Let me think about that" instead of feeling pressured to answer quickly.

Your communication style is valid, and you deserve to be understood.

How do you like to communicate? What strategies would you like to try?





Write or draw here

How do you like to communicate? What strategies would you like to try?



How to Set Boundaries and Say No

A boundary is a limit you set to protect your energy, emotions, or personal space. It's okay to say no to things that make you uncomfortable! Boundaries are healthy and you don't need to feel guilty for having them.

When might you need to set a boundary?

- If a friend expects too much from you.
- If someone is touching you (hugging, grabbing your arm) and you don't like it.
- If a social event is too overwhelming and you need to leave.

How to say no:

- "I don't have the energy for that right now."
- "I need some space, but I'd love to talk later."
- "I'm not comfortable with that."
- "No, but thanks for asking."
- "I need to go now - thanks for understanding."

You have the right to say no without guilt. Your comfort matters.





Write or draw here

Is there a boundary you'd like to practise setting?

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How to Explain my Needs to Others

Sometimes, people don't realise what you need unless you tell them. You deserve to have your needs understood and respected.

Needs you might need to explain:

- Processing time - "I need a moment to think before I answer."
- Sensory sensitivity - "Loud noises make me anxious - can we turn the volume down?"
- Social energy limits - "I can hang out for an hour, but then I need alone time."
- Direct communication - "I don't always pick up on hints. It helps if you say things directly."
- Needing structure - "I feel better when I know the plan in advance."

How to communicate your needs clearly:

- Use simple, direct language - "I need quiet" or "I need space".
- Write things down - if talking is hard, texting or using a communication card can help.
- Use "I" statements - instead of "You're too loud" say "I feel overwhelmed when it's noisy".
- Advocate for your needs - if people don't understand, it's okay to repeat your needs.

Examples of scripts you can use:

- When you need a break - "I'm feeling overwhelmed. I need a quiet space for a while."
- When people pressure you to talk - "I'm not in a talking mood right now, but I like listening."
- When you need clarity - "I don't understand what you mean, can you explain in another way?"
- When someone crosses a boundary - "I'm not comfortable with that. Please stop."

You don't have to change who you are - others can learn to understand you better.





Write or draw here

What's one need you'd like people to understand better?



Friendships: What Works for Me?

Friendships don't have to look the same for everyone. Some people love having lots of friends, while others prefer one or two close friends.

People who may be good friends:

- Friends who respect your boundaries and don't pressure you to socialise when you're tired, overwhelmed, or drained.
- People who share your interests and enjoy talking about them.
- Friends who accept your social style (e.g. not minding when you don't want to talk, take longer to reply, or need space).
- People who understand you might show friendship differently - maybe through acts of kindness rather than words.

People who may not be good friends:

- Friends who only talk to you when they need something but ignore you otherwise.
- People who make fun of your interests.
- Friends who make you feel guilty for needing space or not replying instantly.
- People who don't respect your boundaries or make you feel uncomfortable.

What can help?

- Thinking about how you like to connect - do you prefer texting, gaming, or meeting in person?
- Setting expectations - letting friends know if you need time alone after socialising, or if you don't like certain types of conversations.

What and who do you think could help you with friendships?





Write or draw here

What and who do you think could help you with friendships?



5

School and Learning

Find out how you learn best, and how to make school work for you.

- How my Brain Learns Best
- Homework and Study Strategies
- Talking to Teachers about my Needs
- Making School Work for Me



How My Brain Learns Best

Every brain learns differently, and understanding how your brain works can help you find the best ways to absorb and process information. Here are some key areas where your brain may experience differences:

- Processing information - you may need extra time to absorb and respond to new information, especially in fast-paced lessons.
- Focus and attention - your focus might be deep and intense on topics you love, but you may struggle with subjects that don't interest you.
- Executive functioning - skills like organising tasks, remembering due dates, and switching between subjects can be challenging.

What could help?

- Breaking tasks into small steps - instead of "write a story", try "choose a topic > think of the characters > write or draw some ideas..."
- Use visual aids - mind maps, colour-coded notes, and charts can help with understanding and memory.
- Movement breaks - short breaks between tasks can help reset your focus.
- Consider other ways of learning - videos, hands-on activities, and discussions might work better than reading from a book.

Learning is not about fitting into a system - it's about finding what works for YOU!

What do you think could help you learn?





Write or draw here

What do you think could help you learn?



Homework and Study Strategies

Homework can feel overwhelming - especially after spending all day at school using up your energy. Finding study strategies that match your brain's strengths can help.

Homework hacks:

- Work in short bursts - work in 10-20 minute chunks and have a break in between - whatever works best for you!
- Use your interests - if possible, connect your homework or study to topics you love.
- Have a "homework start" routine - set up a specific space and time to signal your brain that it's study time.
- Reward yourself - small incentives (a break, a snack, or a favourite activity) can help with motivation.
- Ask for extensions if needed - if a task is too much, it's okay to ask for extra time.

Studying doesn't have to be a struggle - you can make it work for YOU!

What strategies do you think could help you?





Write or draw here

What strategies do you think could help you?

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Talking to Teachers About My Needs

Sometimes, teachers may not understand what support you need unless you tell them. It's okay to self-advocate and ask for help.

What to tell teachers:

- How you learn best - "I understand better when I can see things visually."
- What makes school hard - "Fast-paced discussions are tricky for me because I need time to process."
- What helps you succeed - "Having written notes helps me follow along."
- What to avoid - "I get overwhelmed when I'm put on the spot to answer questions."

Ways to communicate your needs:

- Write a note to your teacher if speaking in person is hard.
- Use an advocacy card with key information about your needs.
- Ask to speak with your teacher about your needs.

Advocacy script example:

"I learn best when I can see things visually and have extra time to process information. Could I get written instructions along with verbal ones?"

You have the right to be supported and to learn in a way that works for you!

What would you like the teacher to know?





Write or draw here

What would you like your teacher to know?



Making School Work for Me

School environments can and should be adapted and adjusted to support you and the way you work in the classroom. Small changes can make a big difference!

Classroom adjustments that might help:

- A quiet seating area - sitting near the edge of the classroom, away from distractions.
- Fidget tools - having something to hold can help focus and self-regulation.
- Using ear defenders - reducing background noise to focus better.
- Having written or pictured instructions - clear, step-by-step instructions instead of only verbal ones.
- Using a timer - to help manage focus and time on tasks.

How to advocate for these adjustments:

- Ask a teacher or support staff for changes that can help you focus.
- Use advocacy scripts like "I learn best when I can have visual instructions instead of just verbal ones. Can I get a visual to help me?"
- Speak to a parent or carer about what adjustments you need.

School should be a place where you can thrive, not just survive!

What adjustments do you think would help support you?





Write or draw here

What adjustments do you think would help support you?



6

Self-Advocacy and Self-Esteem

Build confidence, learn your rights, and find your voice.

- Knowing my Rights and Asking for Support
- Building Confidence in Who I Am
- Finding Role Models
- Writing my Own Advocacy Plan



Knowing My Rights and Asking for Support

You have the right to be supported, included, and treated with respect - whether at school, at work, or in daily life. Understanding these rights can help you feel empowered to speak up when you need to.

Your rights include:

- The right to reasonable adjustments in school (e.g. extra time, quiet spaces, and assistive technology).
- The right to advocate for yourself and have your voice heard.
- The right to be treated with respect and not to be forced into uncomfortable situations.
- The right to support for your mental health and well-being.

How to ask for support:

- Be clear about what you need - "I focus better when I can wear ear defenders."
- Use written communication, assistive technology, or communication boards if verbal conversations are overwhelming.
- Ask someone you trust to help advocate for you if needed.

You deserve support. Asking for what you need is not being difficult - it's self-care.





Write or draw here

Is there something you'd like to ask for support with?

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Building Confidence in Who I Am

Feeling good about yourself isn't always easy, especially if you've been made to feel "different" in the past. But being you is not a flaw - it's a different way of experiencing the world, and that is something to celebrate.

Ways to build self-confidence:

- Focus on your strengths - what are you good at? What makes you unique?
- Surround yourself with supportive people - being around those who understand and accept you makes a huge difference.
- Challenge negative self-talk - replace "I'm not good at this" with "I'm learning at my own pace".
- Take pride in your identity - you are great, and you have so many strengths!

You are valuable, just as you are. Your way of thinking and experiencing the world matters.





Write or draw here

What's something you're proud of about yourself?



Role Models

Finding role models who experience the world in a similar way to you can show you that there are many ways to succeed and live a happy life.

Here are some well-known people with brains a bit like yours:

Satoshi Tajiri

Creator of Pokémon

Clay Marzo

Professional Surfer

Ellie Middleton

Author

Greta Thunberg

Environmental Activist

Who are your role models?



Write or draw here

Why do these role models inspire you? Who else inspires you?



Writing My Own Advocacy Plan

Creating an advocacy plan can help you feel more prepared to express your needs and rights in different situations.

Things to consider on your advocacy plan:

- What are my biggest challenges? (e.g. loud environments, verbal instructions, unexpected changes).
- What strategies help me? (e.g. using a visual schedule, having written notes, fidget tools, sensory or calm boxes, taking breaks).
- How do I communicate my needs? (e.g. self-advocacy scripts, writing notes, asking a support person or family for help).
- Who can I ask for support? (e.g. teachers, family, friends).

Advocacy script example:

"I work best when I have clear written instructions and extra processing time. Could I have a checklist to help me stay organised?"

Self-advocacy is a skill that grows with time. The more you practise, the easier it gets.



My Advocacy Plan

Name: _____

My Challenges

Strategies to Help

How I Communicate my Needs

Who Can Support Me

My Advocacy Script



7

My Personal Profile

Bring it all together in your own personal profile.

- My Strengths and Challenges
- What Helps Me Thrive
- How I Like to Communicate
- What I Want People to Know About Me



My Strengths and Challenges

Everyone has things they're great at, and things that can be tricky sometimes. Take a moment to use the prompts below and think about what makes you great and what might be more difficult for you.

Strength prompts:

- I have a great memory for... (facts, numbers, music, details).
- I'm really creative and love... (drawing, writing, making things, problem-solving).
- I notice things that other people don't, like...
- I'm honest, kind, and always try to...
- I can focus really well on...

Challenge prompts:

- I find it hard to...
- Loud noises / lots of people / bright lights can make me feel...
- I sometimes struggle to understand...
- It can be difficult for me to start / finish...
- When plans change, I feel...



My Strengths and Challenges

Name: _____

My Strengths

My Challenges

What Helps Me Thrive

This section is about what makes life easier and more comfortable for you. What helps you feel safe, happy, and focused?

At school, I work best when...

- I have a quiet space to work.
- My teacher gives me extra time to process things.
- I can use... (fidget tools, movement breaks, ear defenders).
- The classroom isn't too bright / loud / crowded.

At home, I feel best when...

- I have time to do...
- My family understands that I need...
- I get to spend time on my interests like...

When I'm overwhelmed, it helps when...

- I can take a break and...
- People give me space / time to...
- Someone reminds me to...



What Helps Me Thrive

Name: _____

At school, I work best when...

At home, I feel best when...

When I'm overwhelmed, it helps when...



How I Like to Communicate

Everyone has their own way of communicating! What feels most natural to you?

Some ideas to get you started:

- I like talking face-to-face / I prefer writing things down / I prefer using a communication board / I prefer using assistive technology.
- I need extra time to think before I respond.
- I find it easier to communicate when... (people use clear language, I have visuals).
- Sometimes, I don't have words for how I feel, but I show it by...
- I prefer short / simple instructions because...
- If I don't understand something, I like people to...



How I Like to Communicate

Name: _____

How I like to communicate

What I Want People to Know About Me

This is where you can tell others what's important about YOU. What would you like teachers, friends, or family to understand?

Some ideas to get you started:

- I am autistic, which means...
- I might seem quiet / shy / loud / confident, but really, I...
- Just because I don't show my emotions the way others do, doesn't mean I don't feel them.
- If I'm overwhelmed, it helps if...
- My special interests are..., and I love talking about them!
- I want people to be patient with me because...
- I am proud of who I am because...



What I Want People to Know About Me

Name: _____

What I want people to know about me